

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world Twenty20

spirit of india special

SPIN-OFFS

Hot Shots



Chris Gayle The captain of the West Indies arrived for a series in England less than 48 hours at its start this year having played his quota of IPL2 games. He then said he "won't cry" if Test cricket were to die.

Younis Khan Pakistan's voluble, earthy, grounded Pathan captain who declared that T20 was really a casual fun thing and then went and won the 2009 World T20.

Side Shows If IPL1 had TV stars resembling pizza delivery boys doing the on-field 'sideline' stuff for TV, IPL2 had cricketers doing the same on the field. There were mike-men pretending to be under the influence.

Cheerleaders Be it the dancers of the 2007 World T20 or the airheads around the Bangalore Royal Challengers, there's no escaping the cheerleaders. Cuttack plans to host an India-Sri Lanka ODI with cheerleaders in Sambhalpuri saris.



RAVISH SAHANI/www.indiatodayimages.com

Key PLAYERS

STUART ROBINSON The Englishman who in 2003 tried to get locals into county grounds by creating a short game of cricket.



LALIT MODI Seen as the force behind the event that took T20 to cricket's stratosphere, Modi talks about the primacy of Test



cricket, but it's not known if he crosses his fingers behind his back.

M.S. DHONI He led his team to victory in World T20 in 2007. Dhoni is also suspected to be the first Indian captain to nurse dreams about a short shrift on the old Test match format.



SHAH RUKH KHAN The owner of Kolkata Knight Riders, the IPL's least successful team.

He showered his team with Tag Heuer watches and high-end laptops. Along with great salaries, of course.



hooked to T20 after their team won that World T20 event. The players and the people involved in the IPL say it's a fantastic tournament. But I'm going to be a bit controversial and I think this is going to rule me out for any IPL deal in the future. I don't see T20 cricket per se to be a massive threat to the Test and ODI cricket. I see international teams playing it, I see World T20, domestic T20 and don't even mind the Champions League that we just had.

But I see the IPL as the major concern. I see it as a purely money-making scheme. Players are already exhausted by the number of matches they play and the IPL is exhausting players even more. The IPL also gives too many international players an easy option to get out, especially those who don't get massively paid like those in England, Australia or India. Take, for instance, the Chris Gayles of the world. If he gets an easy option saying, 'here's six weeks to earn more money than you will earn for five years of playing the West Indies', what is he going to choose? Then you get people retiring a bit early for the IPL when they could have maybe carried on playing for a bit longer.

I think the IPL has slightly diluted the quality of international cricket as you see a lot of injured players nowadays like Brett Lee, Jacob Oram, Andrew Flintoff and Kevin Pietersen. People who have played the IPL, then come back to their countries injured. That's hurting the international game and that to me is the threat.

I wouldn't want cricket to go the way football has in England where playing for Arsenal or Manchester United or any other club is more important than playing for England. With all respect to T20, it's fun but to me it's like a pudding. I know I sound like an old fogey but to me

tournaments like the IPL are like a slice of cake at the end of your tea. Your main course is Test match, ODI and international T20 cricket. When Sachin Tendulkar was getting a century against Australia in the ODI series, my phone was going, 'Are you watching Sachin?'. I kept getting texted. That final which India won in Lord's, where Sourav Ganguly waved his shirt, still hurts me but I have fond memories of it. In the footage, I can see the passion on Ganguly's face as well as mine and that game will be remembered for longer than a T20 match.

I've got nothing against clubs or Indian cricket, I would have done anything to have come to India and play more over there. This is not me, Nasser Hussain, being bitter or twisted about the IPL. But I don't want playing for Punjab Whatevers or Chennai Whatevers to be more important than playing for India.

So in the next decade I would like T20 to be where it is, with a little bit of control. Some of the commentators are busy saying, "It's not an international game, it's a domestic game." I don't agree. I would say it's still very much an international game. There's a buzz at India-Pakistan games, India versus England is a match that switches everyone on. The two world T20s are great events—quick, over in two weeks and everyone enjoys them. Then you move on to Test matches, ODIs. I would want slightly less of the IPL, slightly more of international games but don't kill it. Today, I have to say some parts of the world may be starting to overkill it.

Nasser Hussain is former captain of the England cricket team and a cricket commentator.

